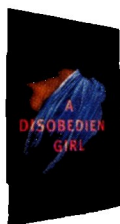


The Second SEX

This Sri Lankan novel is an indictment of a middle class steeped in gender bias



A DISOBEDIENT GIRL

by RU FREEMAN

Viking

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By Gillian Wright

This is a novel not about one but about two disobedient females. Both are strong, lovable and complex characters. Despite some level of education, they belong to the underclass of Sri Lankan society. They are Buddhists, and the author brings to this, her first novel, an authentic flavour of Sinhala culture and the island landscapes. Her two main characters also have in common years spent with nuns in a convent. Biso, a poor "low caste" woman married to an abusive husband was educated by nuns, while Latha, an orphan and servant from early childhood, is packed off to a convent to have an illegitimate baby.

It is not so long ago that in Ireland, another island state, pregnant single mothers were condemned as morally corrupt and consigned to the infamous Magdalen laundries to labour beyond the pale of respectable society for as long as they lived. The Sri Lankan nuns in this book are not so cruel, and girls do have a hope of a return to servant life even if they never know what happens to their babies who are taken away from them at birth. However, there is very little compassion in the way Latha is treated by her employers. Everything is her fault. She is the im-

moral one. The dialogues between the mistress and servant are particularly taut and telling.

Ru Freeman feels a special empathy for the disadvantaged. A journalist now living in the US, she was brought up in a Sri Lankan family of writers and poets at a time of political turmoil. She felt the gender bias against women in her own home and found herself naturally drawn to the company of servants who became the subjects of her early writing. As an adult, she studied labour relations and later worked on American and international humanitarian assistance and workers' rights. This novel therefore resounds with genuine conviction as she indicts middle-class caste-conscious society for treating as invisible and inferior those that serve them, and for being so smug about the unassailable value they put on being from "a good family".

Freeman is by no means the first South Asian author to write of the poor or the servant-employer relationship, but she does so in a lively, fluent style free of cliché. Her narrative is also unusual. Chapters are devoted alternately to the separate stories of Latha and of Biso, with Latha's tale covering 30 years of her life, and Biso's a mere 72 hours of hers. As the two plots progress, Freeman gives tantalising hints at connections between the two, leaving the reader to try to guess how they are related. In a way, the rhythm of the alternately changing chapters on the route to an unexpected denouement seems to reflect the clattering of Biso's train over the tracks as it heads up from the coast into the central mountains, climbing through tea estates and around contours on its way to Badulla, the end of the line.

In contrast to Biso and Latha, the male characters appear flimsy and weak. However, this is perhaps natural when the central characters are so feisty. This is not a book of dark despair, nor entirely of black and white. Latha and her mistress's daughter Thara in particular reach over the line dividing servant and employer in many ways and break rules. Latha has a concept of her own worth, perhaps born through education and her ability to survive. She knows she is tougher than her employers. Altogether, this is a compelling first novel, full of action and suspense, loyalty, love and betrayal. ■

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